A third member of the core team was believed to be Shaktikanta Das, the then Economic Affairs Secretary.[27] A Tamil Nadu-cadre IAS officer with roots in Odisha and a postgraduate from St. Stephen's College, he had spent almost a decade in the North Block, India's Ministry of Finance. Post-demonetization, Das became the 'public face' of the MoF, fielding questions from the media and holding press conferences to announce and explain the convoluted rules and their frequent changes. On his retirement in November 2017, Das was appointed India's G20 Sherpa.[28]

Whether these three senior officials were in fact part of the core planning team or not, is hard to confirm. However, there is no doubt that the Prime Minister himself was the principal architect of the move. Press reports stated that three ministers who had attended the Cabinet meeting on 8 November 2016 shortly before demonetization was announced, shared that the Prime Minister had said, 'I have done all the research and, if it fails, then I am to blame.'[29]

When Did the RBI Board Approve the Demonetization Decision?

Speaking in the Rajya Sabha on 16 November 2016, the Union Power Minister, Piyush Goyal, while defending demonetization, asserted that the 'the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) runs the monetary policy of the nation and this decision was taken by the RBI board.'

In the absence of the minutes of the Board's meeting, which RBI has to date refused to make public, all that can be reliably said about when the decision was made and who made it, is drawn from the RBI's written submissions to the Parliament's PAC and Parliamentary Finance panel.

The PAC was informed that demonetization was under discussion between the government and the RBI for 'some months', following which the proposal was placed before the Central Board of RBI on 8 November 2016 for consideration.